Chapter 16 – East India Company Rule

Facing constant pressure from other European merchant companies in India, the British focused their energy on strengthening the city's main military outpost, Fort William. Outraged that his order to stop such fortifications had gone unheeded, Siraj ud-Daulah marched on Calcutta with 50,000 soldiers, 500 elephants, and 50 cannons in June of 1756. Unprepared for such an attack, the British troops fled Fort William for the relative safety of their ships in the nearby harbor. Ud-Daulah's forces easily entered the city and took everyone prisoner.

There was one prison room within the walls of the city, and it measured about 20 square meters (215 square feet). Though plenty of space for a few petty criminals, it was not at all equipped to hold the 164 prisoners of war who the Nawab imprisoned there. Most within the cell, known henceforth as the Black Hole of Calcutta, either suffocated or were trampled to death. When the Nawab ordered the door open the next morning at 6 a.m., only a reported 21 people had survived.

News spread quickly to Lieutenant Colonel Robert Clive, stationed with British troops at Fort Saint George in Madras. When repeated attempts at diplomacy met with no answer, Clive made haste for Fort William with Admiral Charles Watson, a contingent of soldiers, and their Indian allies. Clive's forces liberated the British and Indian prisoners of the Nawab on January 2nd, 1757, and took their own prisoners. With Fort William secure, Clive marched onward in search of the nawab himself, who had moved on from Calcutta before British reinforcement had arrived.

Continued attacks by Clive on ud-Daulah's army convinced the latter to attempt the diplomacy he had not bothered with after the siege of Fort William, but it was too late to talk. Hounded by the British wherever he went, Nawab Siraj ud-Daulah staged one last violent stand against the commercial colonialists. Members of the French East India Company were more than willing to help, especially since France was currently at war with Great Britain. It was a fight that Monsieur Sinfray, a French artillery officer, was willing to join.

Siraj ud-Daulah mustered a huge army of more than 60,000 soldiers with the help of fellow Mughal leaders and Sinfray. On the opposing side were a mere 3,000, pieced together from British soldiers and European or Indian allies, all under the leadership of Robert Clive. Each side was well-armed